

Brightway 2.5 Assistant

Installation. About 15 minutes. No terminal experience needed.

github.com/lotteat11/brightway25-assistant

1 Install VS Code

code.visualstudio.com

2 Install Python

python.org/downloads — skip if you already have it.

Windows: tick “Add python.exe to PATH” during installation. Miss it and nothing below works.

3 Open a terminal in VS Code

Terminal → **New Terminal**. A panel opens at the bottom.

Windows: click the **v** next to **+** and choose **Git Bash** (install [Git for Windows](#) if it's missing). PowerShell won't work.

4 Paste and press Enter

```
git clone https://github.com/lotteat11/brightway25-assistant.git
cd brightway25-assistant
bash setup.sh
```

Press Enter again when it asks what you want to use it for. Takes ~5 minutes. Done when it says **Done**.

5 Open the folder, not the file

File → **Open Folder...** → `brightway25-assistant`

The assistant only loads when the whole folder is open. Open a single notebook and you get a plain AI that writes Brightway 2 code that doesn't run.

6 Install an AI assistant

GitHub Copilot is **free**. Click the Copilot icon in the status bar at the bottom → **Use AI Features** → sign in with GitHub.

Claude Code and Cursor also work, but are paid.

7 Set the kernel

Open `my-project/first_lca.ipynb` and accept the **Jupyter** extension when VS Code offers it. Then click the kernel name in the top right and pick **Python (bw25)**.

8 Check it works

Run all cells. It should print **80.0**. Warnings about `scikit-umfpack` and `geocollections` are harmless.

9 Start your own exercise

That notebook was only a check. For your own work, right-click inside `my-project/` in the sidebar → **New File...** → name it something ending in `.ipynb`.

A new notebook always opens on the wrong kernel, so set it the same way: click the kernel name top right → **Python (bw25)**. Then check the first cell prints a path containing `.venv`:

```
import sys; print(sys.executable)
```

Wrong kernel gives you `ModuleNotFoundError: No module named 'bw2data'` even though it is installed — the notebook is just running a different Python. Don't reinstall anything; change the kernel.

Keep everything inside `brightway25-assistant` — subfolders are fine. Put a notebook outside it and the assistant silently won't load.

10 Check the assistant is there

Ask it: *"How do I run a Monte Carlo in Brightway 2.5?"*

CORRECT Mentions `use_distributions=True`

WRONG Mentions `MonteCarloLCA` — you opened a file, not the folder. Back to step 5.

11 ecoinvent, later

Needs your own licence. Log in at ecoinvent.org in a browser first and accept both agreements — until you do, it won't work from Python and the error won't tell you why. Details in `GETTING-STARTED.md`, step 4.

Stuck? Ask the assistant and paste the whole error.